

Funding Your Nonprofit

Once you're a 501(c)(3), a whole world of grants and funding opens up. Below are the best national places to find money for your mission. Tick the box once you've checked each one.

⚠ BEFORE YOU START

Most foundation grants require 501(c)(3) status first. Many funding databases are free at your public library. Beware of "grant writers" who guarantee results for big upfront fees.

1 Find Grants

The main databases for foundation and government grants.

☐ **Candid / Foundation Directory**

The biggest database of foundation grants — free to use at many public libraries (Funding Information Network).

→ candid.org

☐ **Grants.gov**

Federal grants, including many for nonprofits and community programs.

→ www.grants.gov

☐ **Find Your Local Community Foundation**

Community foundations fund local nonprofits. Search your area + "community foundation."

→ **Search your area + 'community foundation'**

2 Free & Discounted Resources

Major in-kind support that stretches your budget.

☐ **Google for Nonprofits**

Free Google Workspace plus up to \$10,000/month in Google Ad Grants to promote your mission.

→ www.google.com/nonprofits

☐ **TechSoup — Discounted Tech**

Deeply discounted software and hardware for nonprofits.

→ www.techsoup.org

3 Raise Money From People

Individual donors are the largest source of nonprofit funding.

☐ **Set Up Online Donations**

Free and low-cost tools let you accept donations online. Many nonprofits start here before chasing grants.

→ www.councilofnonprofits.org/running-nonprofit/fundraising-and-resource-development

☐ **AmeriCorps / VISTA**

Get funded volunteers to build your capacity.

→ americorps.gov/partner

4 Get Grant-Writing Help

Free and low-cost help making your applications strong.

☐ SCORE & Council of Nonprofits

Free mentoring and resources for fundraising and grant writing.

→ www.score.org

⚠ WATCH OUT FOR

Don't pay a grant writer who "guarantees" funding or charges a percentage of grants — that's against fundraising ethics. Use the free Candid database at your library before paying for grant research.

★ A TIP THAT HELPS

Don't rely on grants alone — build a base of individual donors too. Foundations like to fund nonprofits that already have community support, so a few small donors make grant applications stronger.

NEED HELP WHERE YOU LIVE?

Need help where you live?

This guide covers national resources. For local foundations and community grants near you, use the personalized AI search or ask in the Questions area.

MY NOTES — WHO I CALLED, WHEN, AND WHAT THEY SAID
